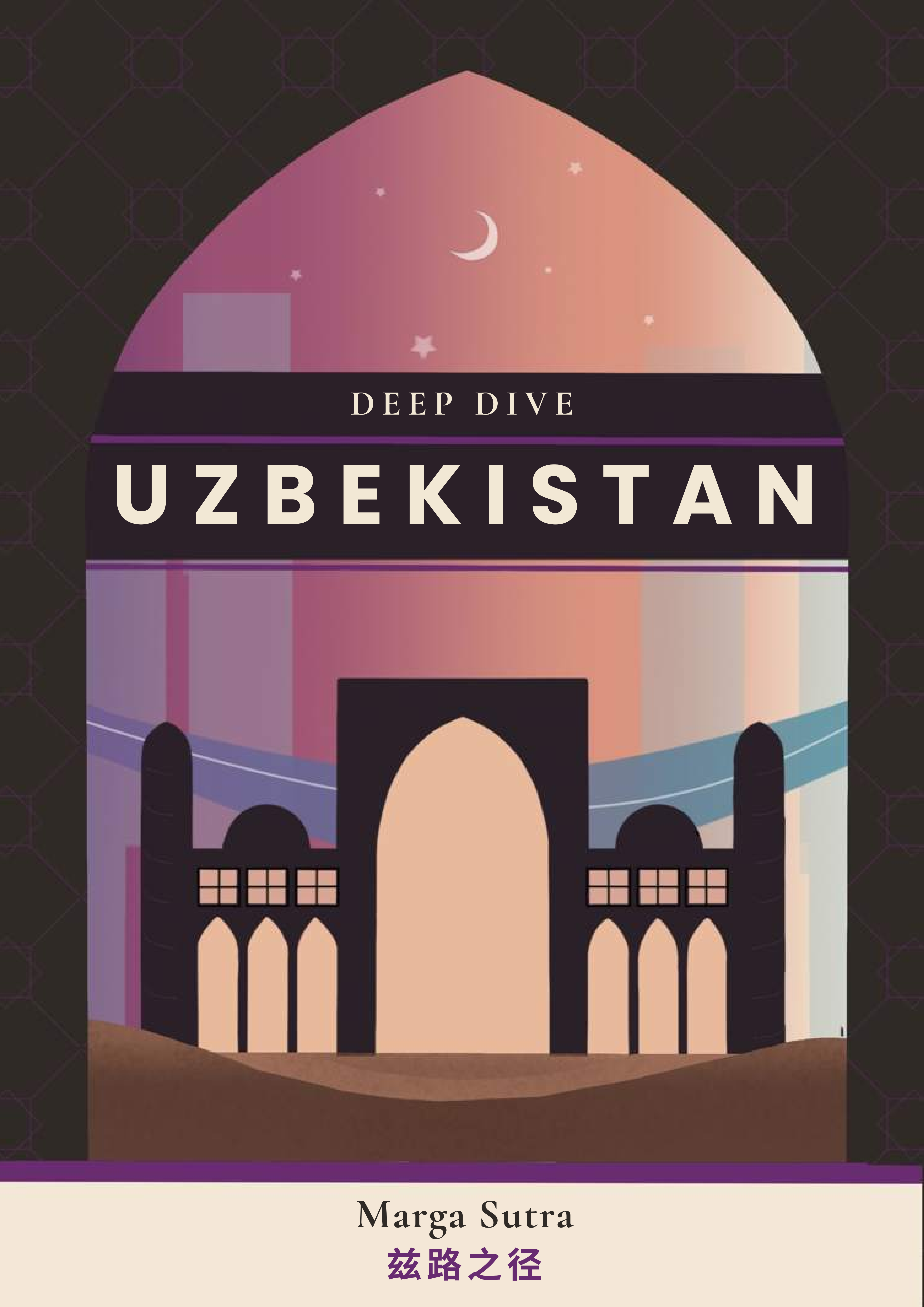




DEEP DIVE

UZBEKISTAN

Marga Sutra
兹路之径

OVERSEAS SOCIAL PRACTICE • JULY 2026

DEEP DIVE

UZBEKISTAN

TASHKENT • SAMARKAND • BUKHARA

10–20 July 2026

Marga Sutra

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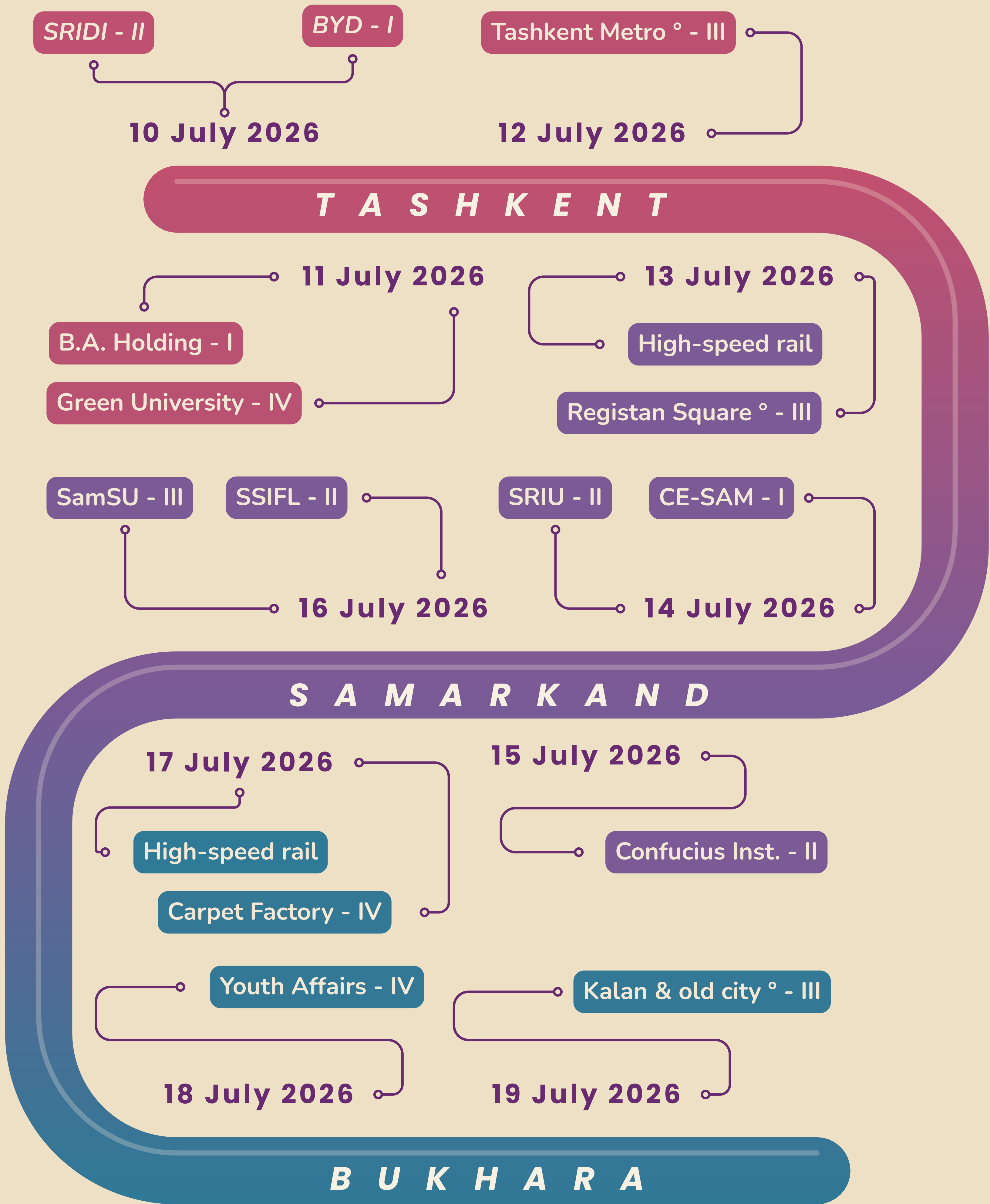
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The Routes

Eleven institutions and three public sites, moving west. The book is sorted by what each place converts rather than where it sits, so the numerals show which channel each visit belongs to.



I CAPITAL

II KNOWLEDGE

III INHERITANCE

IV CAPABILITY

° Visited without a host, guide or interpreter



FOREWORD

From the Supervising Teacher

Li Zhengxin 李正新

Writing and
Communication Center,
Tsinghua University;
Supervising Teacher.

Seeking wisdom through deep dives, nurturing talents amid hands-on practice. The Global Deep Dive Program of Zijing College is an exceptional course. It empowers students to better understand shifts in technology and society through international deep dive practices. Within these immersive investigations, students gain deeper insights into genuine social needs and development trends.

As the faculty leader for this trip, I guided our students to Uzbekistan, a pivotal hub along the Silk Road, to witness the integration of technology, art and economy. I was repeatedly amazed by the passion and wisdom our students demonstrated throughout interviews and field observations. Local interviewees along the journey also gave them thumbs-up time and again, praising their thoughtful questions and unique perspectives.

In the age of AI, while much content can be generated by artificial intelligence, the distinctive observational and analytical abilities cultivated through international deep dives can never be replaced by AI. More importantly, through conversations with diverse communities along the Silk Road, students have developed a stronger sense of mission and responsibility: to guide technology toward good, enabling it to better serve human holistic development, international cooperation and global governance.

This collection features first-hand observations illuminated by youthful wisdom and footprints bearing young people's sense of mission. I hope you will encounter these vivid deep dive stories as you read and discover a brand-new world!



Fourteen Ways

of Converting Something

Uzbekistan takes in three things: foreign money, foreign knowledge and an inheritance of its own. Much of the money and knowledge now comes from China, under the Belt and Road Initiative. The question is the output: what can the country do by itself afterwards? Economists call this absorptive capacity, the ability to take something from outside and make it your own.

We are four Indonesian students at Tsinghua. In eleven days, we watched fourteen places convert something.

I · CAPITAL

- 12

A family firm

each stage of the country

→

a new business
- 15

A cement plant

limestone

→

cement
- engineers

→

teachers
- 16

A car venture

majority ownership

→

jobs, not yet batteries

II · KNOWLEDGE

- 20

A publisher

a Chinese exam

→

an Uzbek book
- 23

A university

photo stops

→

tourism careers
- 25

A language institute

an AI threat

→

a new plan
- 26

A Chinese partner

a language class

→

a career path

III · INHERITANCE

- 30

A square

student rooms

→

craft stalls
- 33

A university

an old madrasa

→

a family tree
- 35

A Bukhara block

workshop by day

→

restaurant by night
- 36

A Soviet metro

a lost partner

→

a finished experiment

IV · CAPABILITY

- 40

A university

ecology

→

legal careers
- 43

A youth center

a ban on AI

→

real skill
- 44

A workshop

a map of knots

→

a free skill

Fourteen conversions. What they add up to: p.46

The Team

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Marga Sutra
兹路之径

How to Read This Book

Four channels, one card, and one mark

We traveled west, from Tashkent to Samarkand to Bukhara. However, this book is sorted by what each place converts. The color on each page tells you which channel you are in.

1 · FOUR CHANNELS

I

CAPITAL · p.11

What money buys, and what it doesn't

II

KNOWLEDGE · p.19

Which way the teaching travels

III

INHERITANCE · p.29

Buildings that never stopped working

IV

CAPABILITY · p.39

What stays when the partner leaves

2 · ONE CARD

Every article ends with a field pass: five short answers to the same questions, so you can compare any two places.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS



CHANNEL

C

SITE	CITY
B.A. Holding	Tashkent
A STARTED BY An Uzbek family business	SUCCESS MEANS Moving with the country's next stage
WHO GETS IN More than 4,000 employees	RUNNING SINCE 2007
B IF THE PARTNER LEFT Brand contracts are the risk	

I

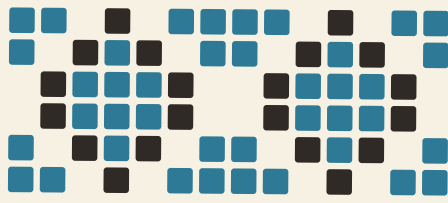
CAPITAL

DATE

11 Jul

PAGE

p.12



KNOT CODE

A · Five short answers: who started it, who gets in, what counts as success.

B · The big question: if the partner left tomorrow, what would happen?

C · Channel, date and page, on the tear-off stub.

3 · ONE MARK



A ° means we visited without a host, guide or interpreter. What we say there, we saw for ourselves.

This book is the short version. The full report, with every source, is one QR code away on p.51.





CHANNEL I – CAPITAL

What Money Buys and What It Doesn't

Three companies: one shared with the Uzbek state, one wholly Chinese-owned, one Uzbek family firm heading for the stock market. What does each leave behind?

B.A. Holding: What Comes After Steel

A family company that grows by reading the country's next stage. Steel paid for the building years. Next comes digital.

Gulbakhor Baxodirovna, the CEO of B.A. Holding, told us the story at the group's Tashkent headquarters. It began with fruit and vegetables in the Namangan region. After the 2017 reforms, the family moved to the capital to follow the national rebuilding.

That move set the pattern: grow into whatever the country needs next. While Uzbekistan was building new city districts, industrial zones and infrastructure, metallurgy became the group's main source of profit. Today more than 4,000 people work across its businesses, from construction and textiles for brands such as Zara and H&M to private banking, IT and education.

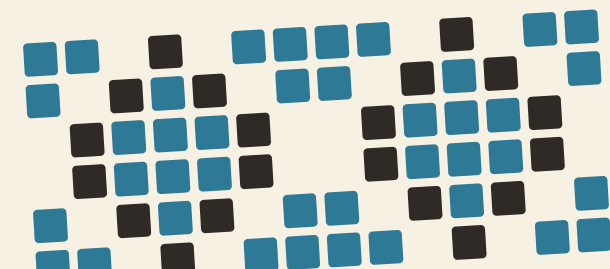
Now, the CEO told us, the building stage is over, and metallurgy earns less than it did. The group is not holding on. It has spent about \$20 million modernizing its furnaces, drops businesses that underperform, and is turning toward the country's next stage, which the government calls Digital Uzbekistan. It also plans a stock market listing, so that decisions depend less on one family at the top.

Some companies follow a market. This one follows the country.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

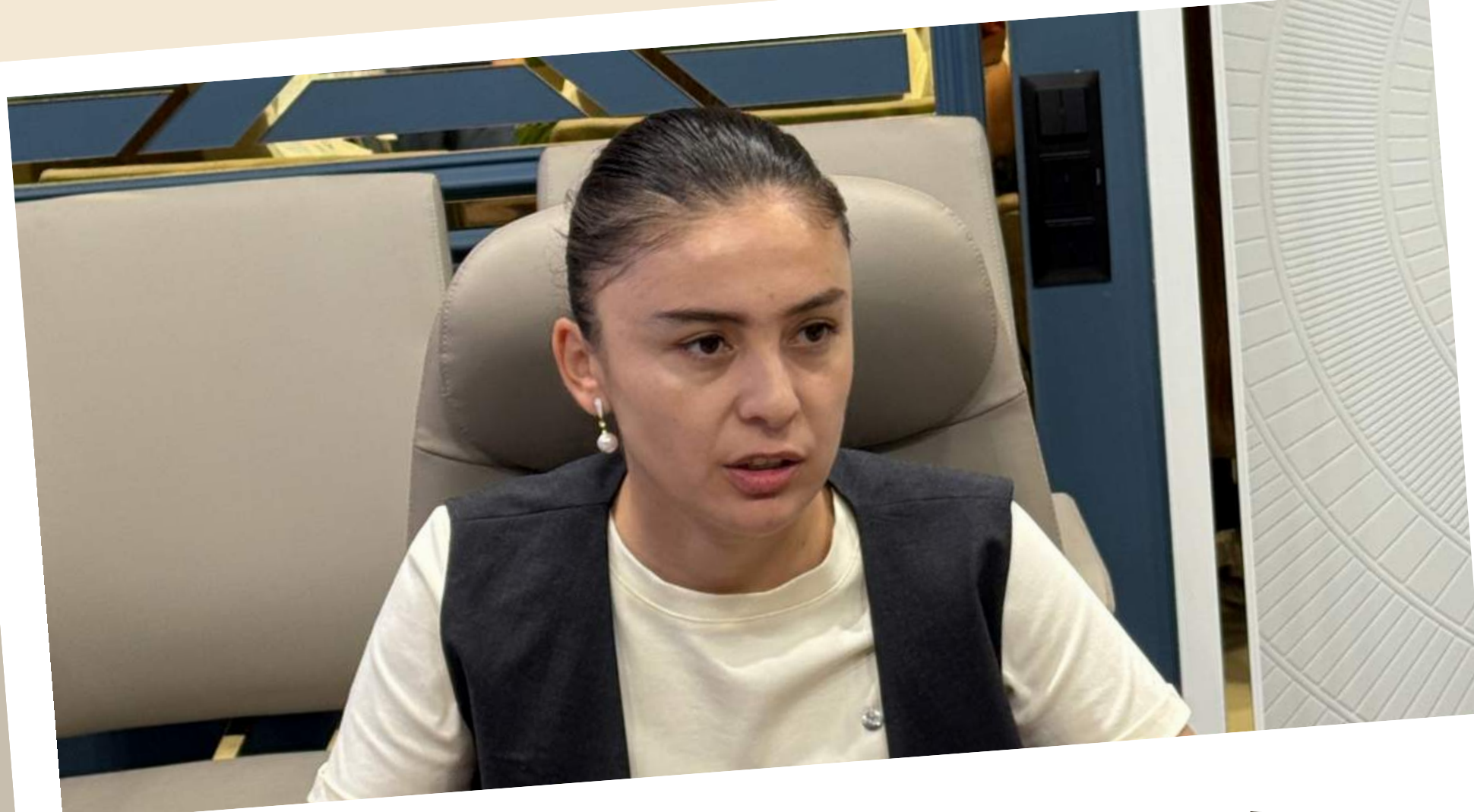


CHANNEL

SITE	CITY		
B.A. Holding	Tashkent	CAPITAL	
STARTED BY	SUCCESS MEANS	DATE	PAGE
An Uzbek family business	Moving with the country's next stage	11 Jul	p.12
WHO GETS IN	RUNNING SINCE		
More than 4,000 employees	2007	KNOT CODE	
IF THE PARTNER LEFT			
Brand contracts are the risk			

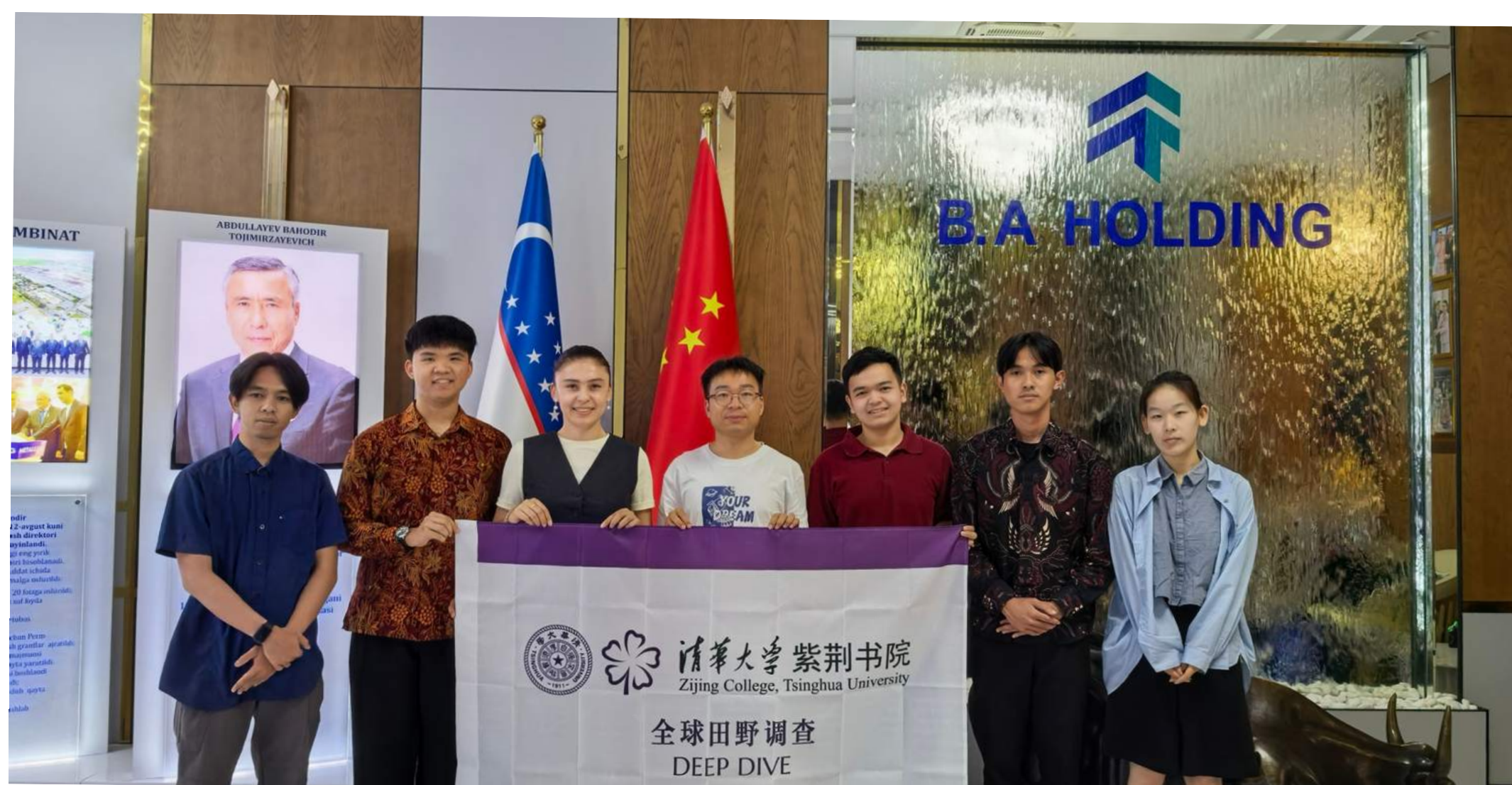
B.A. HOLDING · TASHKENT · 11 JUL

Meeting room: Meeting B.A. Holding at the group's Tashkent headquarters, 11 July 2026.



Speaker: CEO Gulbakhor Baxodirovna traced the group from fruit and vegetable farms in Namangan to more than 4,000 employees.

Exhibition: On the first floor, she walked us through the story of the founder, her father.



Group photo: Marga Sutra with our hosts, under the B.A. Holding sign.

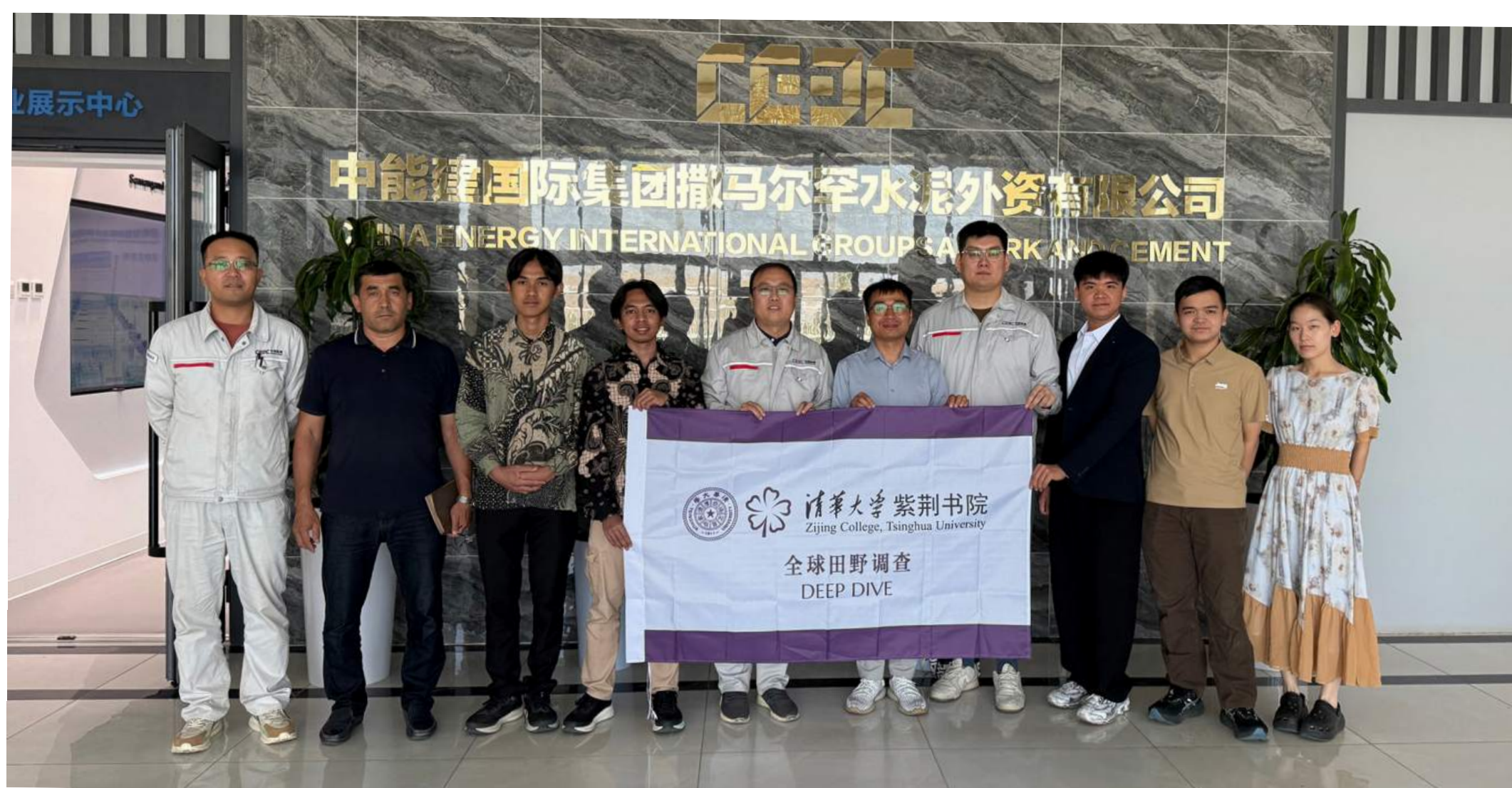
CE-SAM · SAMARKAND · 14 JUL

Meeting: Interviewing the plant manager and the safety and environment director,
14 July 2026.



Control room: The central control room, as far into the plant as safety rules allowed.

Walking outside: Hard hats on to meet our guide, 80 km outside Samarkand.



Group photo: Marga Sutra with our hosts at the CE-SAM entrance.

CE-SAM: Cementing China-Uzbekistan Relations

No Uzbek owns a single share of this cement plant. Almost four in five of its workers are Uzbek.

Before we could enter, we sat through a safety briefing and put on protective gear. Even then, the tour stopped at the central control room. The plant sits 80 km east of Samarkand, beside the limestone it turns into cement.

CE-SAM belongs entirely to three Chinese companies. There is no Uzbek partner. Yet the company's own figures list 257 local employees and 70 Chinese.

Managers explained how. At most plants, the best engineer is the one who fixes a fault fastest. Here, we were told, that job has been rewritten. Under a master-and-apprentice system, the Chinese engineer stands beside an Uzbek colleague and teaches, so that local managers can one day run the plant themselves. Vocational students also visit, and some are placed straight into jobs.

Whether locals could run it alone is still management's claim, and one morning was not enough to test it. What we can say is this: the shares point one way, and the staff list points the other.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

CE-SAM

STARTED BY

Three Chinese firms;
no Uzbek owner

WHO GETS IN

257 local staff, 70 Chinese

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

Continues, management says (untested)

CITY

Samarkand

SUCCESS MEANS

Clean emissions and
local staff

RUNNING SINCE

First cement sold
November 2023

CHANNEL

I

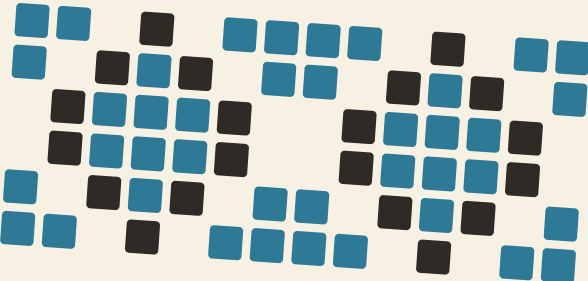
CAPITAL

DATE

14 Jul

PAGE

p.15



KNOT CODE

Fifty-One Percent, and What It Doesn't Buy

Uzbekistan's state carmaker owns most of BYD's local factory. The batteries still come from China.

We met BYD on a showroom floor in Tashkent, with the regional sales office one floor up. We never saw the factory itself, which is in Jizzakh, so what follows is what managers told us.

The factory is a joint venture. Managers told us the larger share, 51%, belongs to UzAuto, Uzbekistan's state-owned carmaker. The design is smart. Because the company is partly Uzbek, its cars avoid the import tariffs that hold back foreign rivals. Production began in June 2024.

Ownership, however, does not decide what is made here. Seats, glass and bumpers are produced locally, because they need many workers and the government requires it. Batteries and car body frames, which need heavy investment, come from China, and no car leaves the line without them. BYD's published plan promises to make batteries here later. After 25 months, the factory has not caught up with the plan.

The next plant in this chapter has no Uzbek owners at all. Its story runs the other way.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

BYD

STARTED BY

BYD, with UzAuto, the state carmaker

WHO GETS IN

About 1,200 jobs now, 10,000 planned by 2030

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

Stops: key parts are imported

CITY

Tashkent

SUCCESS MEANS

Cars built and sold

RUNNING SINCE

June 2024

CHANNEL

I

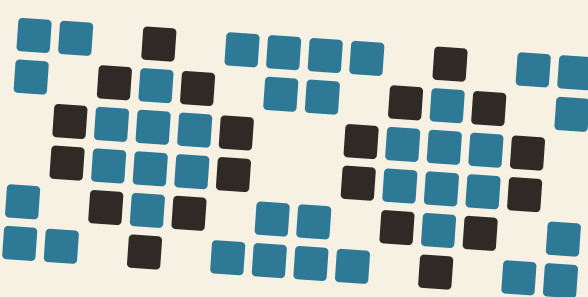
CAPITAL

DATE

10 Jul

PAGE

p.16

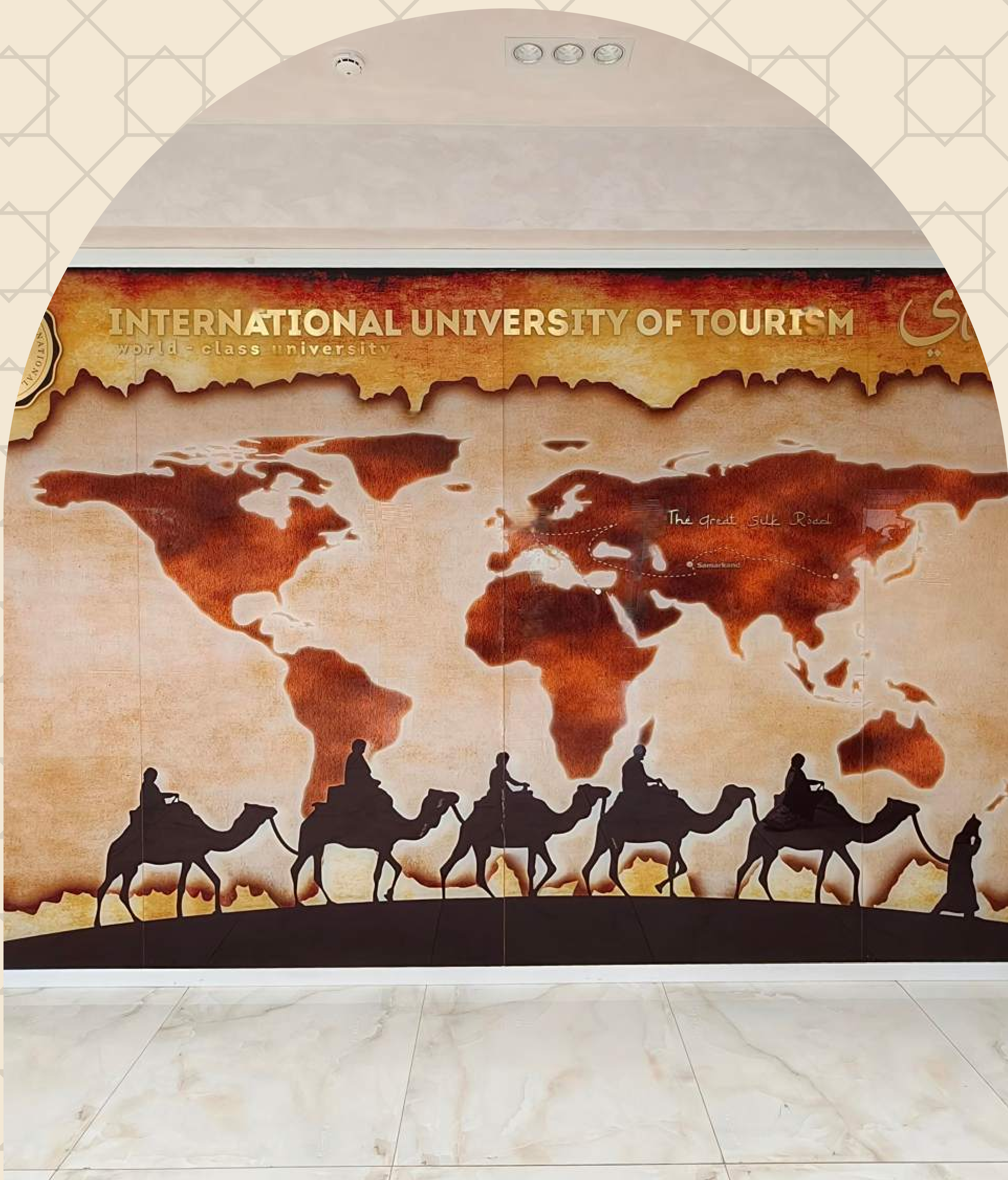


KNOT CODE

CHANNEL I • CAPITAL

Who owns a company decides who shares the profit. It does not decide what stays behind.





CHANNEL II – KNOWLEDGE

Which Way the Teaching Travels

Four institutions move language and learning between China and Uzbekistan, in both directions. What does the learner still have when the class ends?

SRIDI: A Textbook as Infrastructure

A Chinese textbook written in Uzbek sounds like a small thing. For students outside the capital, it works like a road.

The first thing we noticed in SRIDI's Tashkent office was the books: real ones, stacked on shelves and tables. SRIDI is a private company that helps Uzbek students study in China. We met its president, O'tabek To'laganov, and Iskandar Ergashov, editor-in-chief of its publishing house.

The books explain the company. Tashkent studies largely in Russian, but the provinces read mostly in Uzbek. Until recently, materials for HSK, China's standard Chinese exam, existed here only in Russian or English. A village student without Russian was shut out before the first lesson. Working with Beijing Language and Culture University, SRIDI's publishing house produced an HSK textbook in Uzbek.

Its counselors have helped several hundred students into Chinese universities. Even so, they told us that numbers are not their measure. Honest advice, fitted to each student, comes first.

A road keeps working after its builder leaves, and so does a textbook. If SRIDI closed tomorrow, its books would still be in provincial classrooms.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

SRIDI

STARTED BY

An Uzbek private company

WHO GETS IN

Any student who reads Uzbek

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

Continues: the books stay

CITY

Tashkent

SUCCESS MEANS

The right advice, not more enrollments

RUNNING SINCE

2015

CHANNEL

II

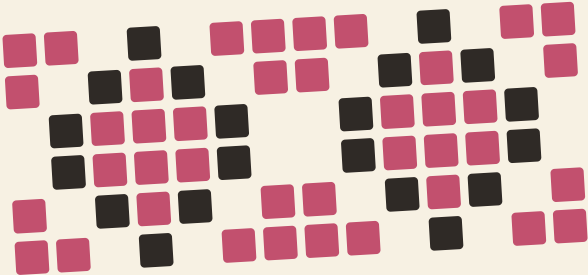
KNOWLEDGE

DATE

10 Jul

PAGE

p.20

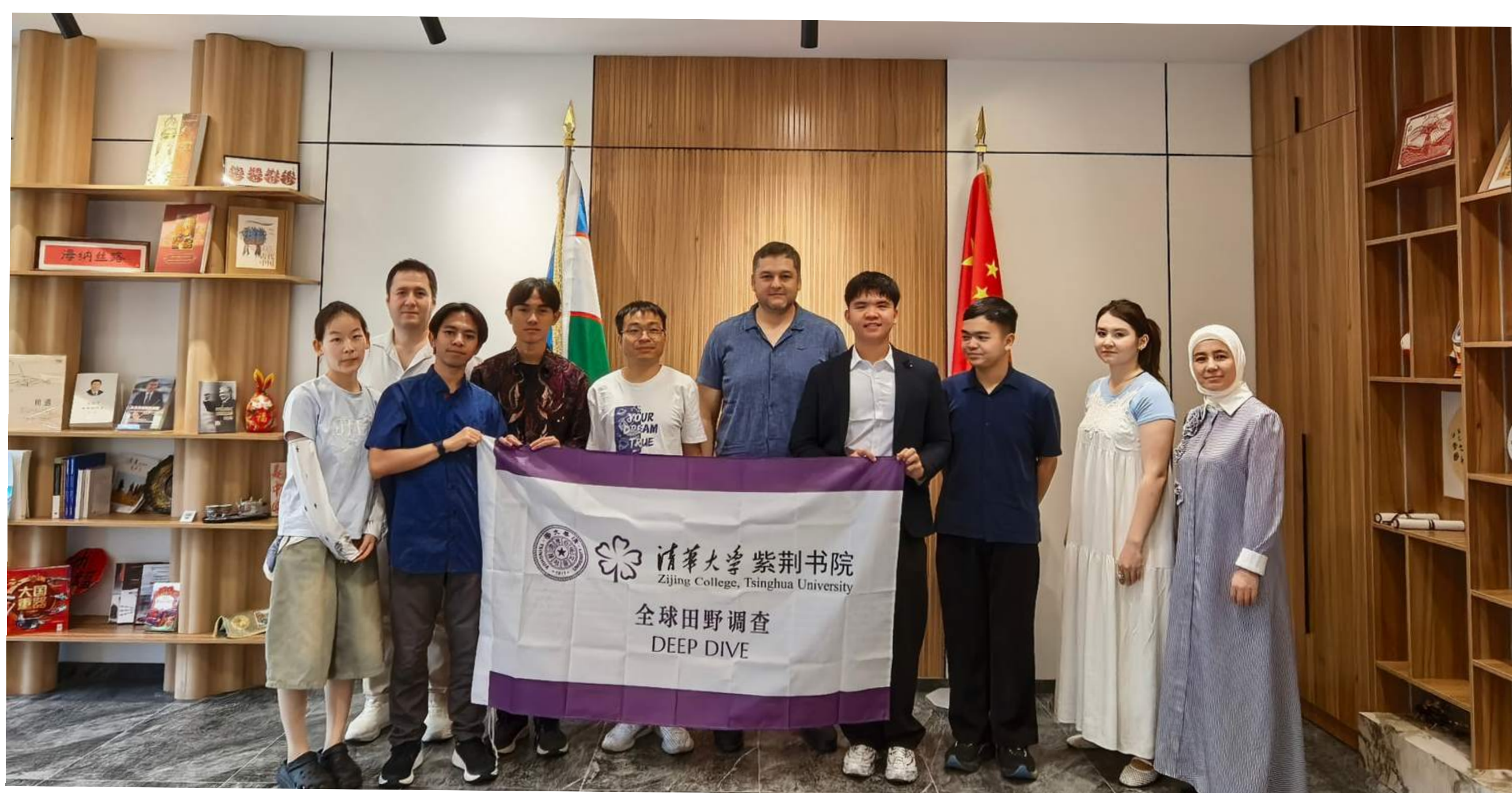


KNOT CODE

SRIDI · TASHKENT · 10 JUL



Meeting room: SRIDI told us how it made the first HSK textbook in Uzbek, 10 July 2026.



Group photo: Marga Sutra with our hosts among the institute's books.

SRIU · SAMARKAND · 14 JUL

The panel: Chinese teachers and entrepreneurs who work in Uzbekistan, 14 July 2026.



Yang Jie: more than 80% of faculty and doctoral students come from abroad.

The campus exhibition of costumes and suzani embroidery.



The SRIU lobby, Samarkand.

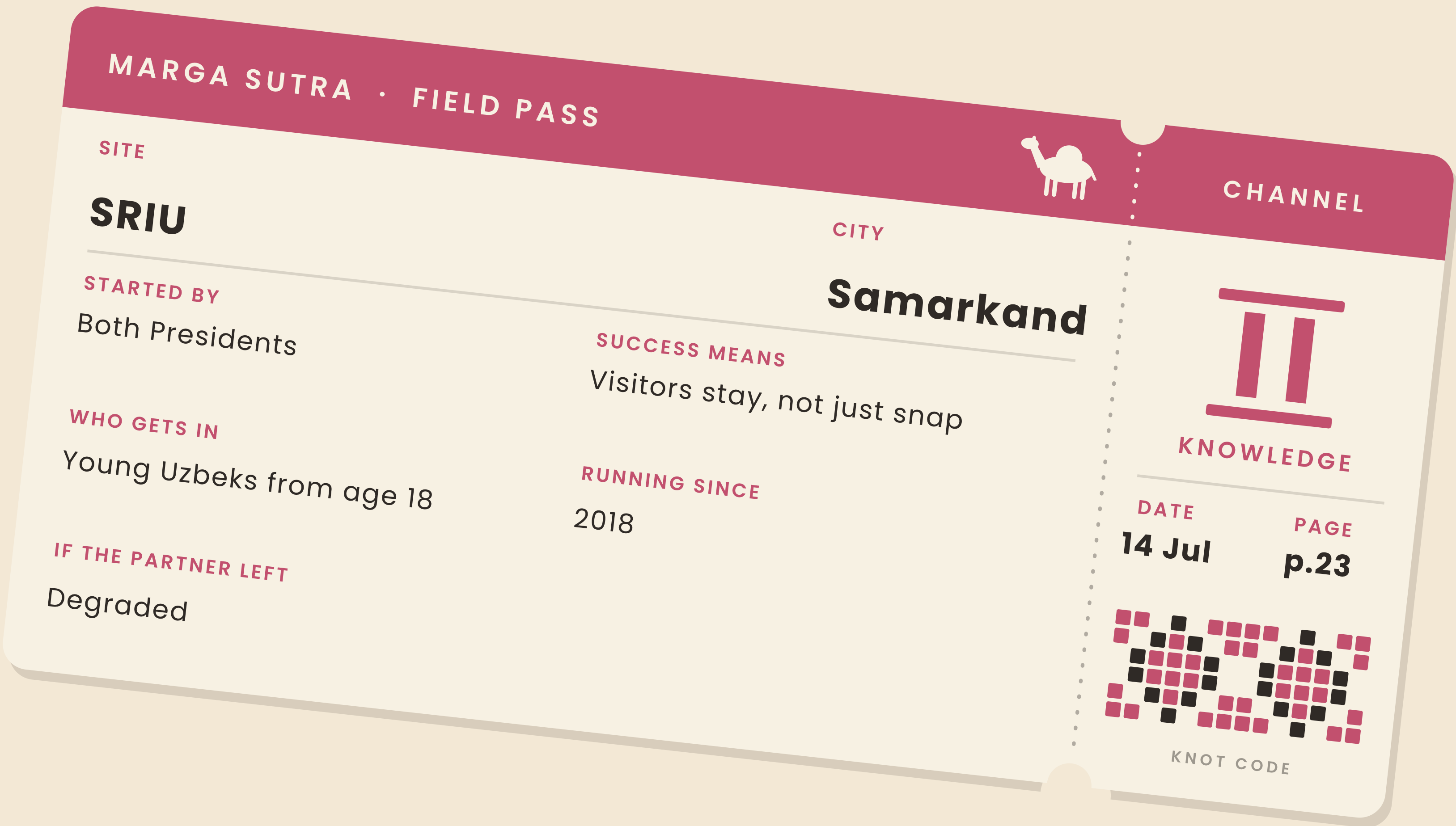
SRIU: Uzbekistan Being More Than a Photo Stop

Visitors come, take a picture and leave. This university was built to make them stay.

Silk Road International University of Tourism and Cultural Heritage felt international the moment we stepped on campus on 14 July. Yang Jie, a Chinese doctoral student who teaches here, told us that more than 80% of faculty and doctoral students come from abroad. SRIU was founded in 2018 with the backing of both countries' presidents, and its first director was Uzbekistan's Minister of Tourism. It also hosts a China–Uzbekistan Belt and Road International Laboratory, which uses technology to preserve cultural heritage.

Yang Jie named the problem the university exists to solve: visitors arrive, photograph a monument and leave. The answer is to train young Uzbeks, from the age of eighteen, for hotels, restaurants and travel agencies, so a visit becomes an experience.

Our session was a panel of Chinese teachers and entrepreneurs, not the university's leadership, and they spoke freely. Uzbekistan, they said, is a blue-ocean market, a break from neijuan (内卷), the exhausting competition back home. They also said that openness at the presidential level fades at the local office, and that online shops struggle because customers prefer to pay cash on delivery.



SSIFL · SAMARKAND · 16 JUL

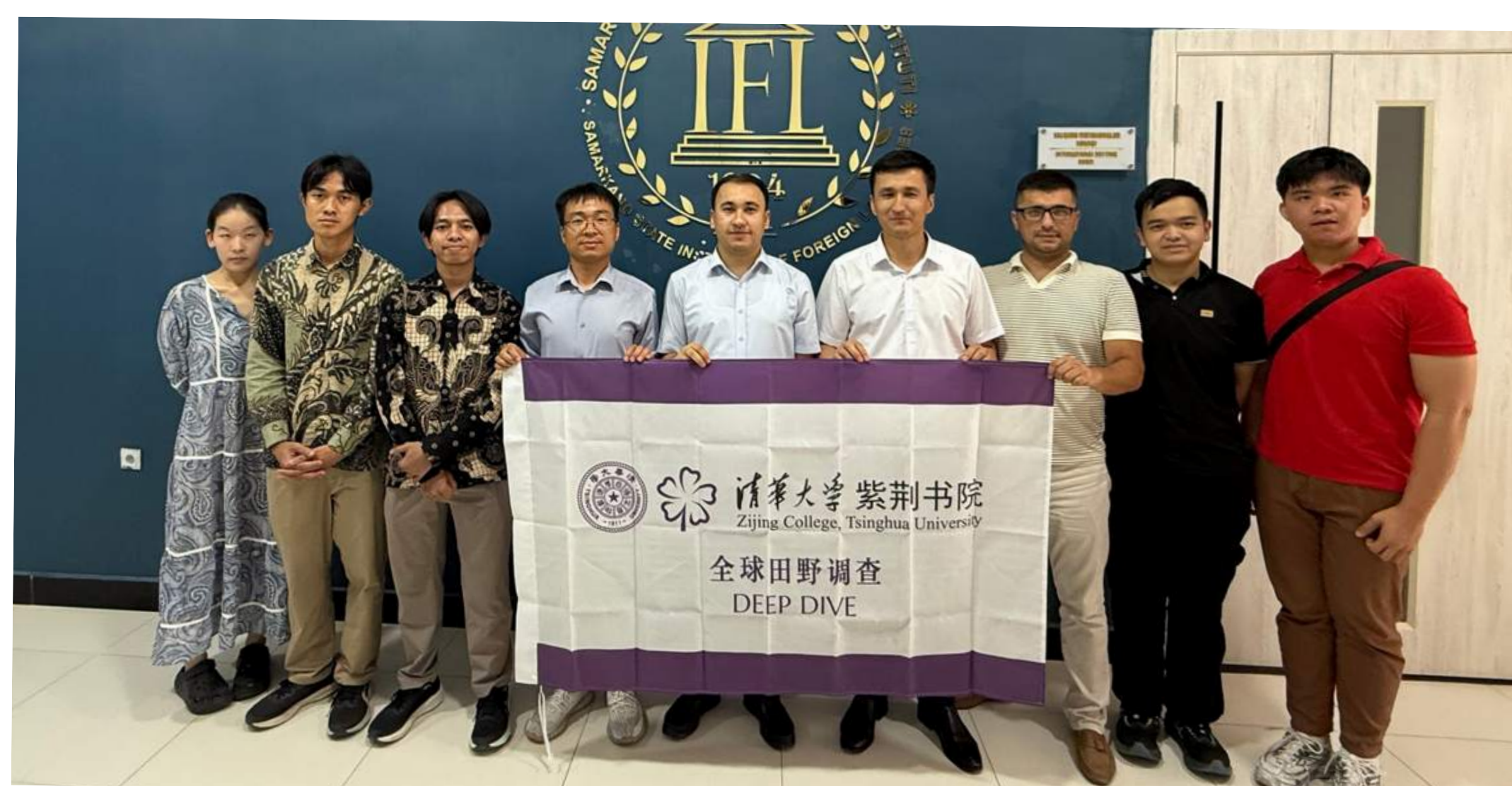
Hosts: SSIFL's leadership told us about its branch faculties in Narpay and Payariq, 16 July 2026.



Our side of the table: Marga Sutra taking notes during the exchange.



Meeting room: the talk turned to whether AI will replace translators.



Group photo: Marga Sutra with our hosts under the institute's emblem.

SSIFL: The Question That Wasn't Prepared

We arrived with fourteen prepared questions. The most useful answer came from one we had not written down.

Samarkand lives on tourism, so here a foreign language is not an academic hobby. It is a job skill. SSIFL, a state institute, is built around that fact.

We had brought fourteen questions, on bridge languages, rural branches and jobs. None was about artificial intelligence. When we asked anyway, the administration already had an answer. They expect AI to threaten ordinary translation jobs within five to ten years. So the institute is not waiting. It is expanding beyond translation into work that is harder to automate, most visibly through its International Relations department.

The state helps from the other side. Any citizen under thirty who reaches C1 level gets the official certificate free. Branch faculties in the Narpay and Payariq districts bring classes to farming areas, so rural students do not have to move to the city.

Most institutions react to a change after it arrives. This one is rebuilding its curriculum for a change it has not yet felt.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

SSIFL

STARTED BY

The Uzbek state

WHO GETS IN

Free certification for under-30s at C1

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

Continues: funded and staffed at home

CITY

Samarkand

SUCCESS MEANS

Preparing for jobs that will still exist

RUNNING SINCE

1994

CHANNEL

II

KNOWLEDGE

DATE

16 Jul

PAGE

p.25

KNOT CODE

The Confucius Institute: Four Languages in One Classroom

So far, the push in this chapter has come from Uzbekistan. At the Confucius Institute, it comes from China.

The Confucius Institute sits inside SSIFL, but it is China's half of the bridge. It opened in November 2014 as a partnership with Shanghai International Studies University. It is one of two in Uzbekistan, and the other, in Tashkent, was the first in Central Asia. China also has formal cooperation agreements with eighteen Uzbek universities.

What staff talked about most was motivation. European learners, they told us, often study Chinese out of cultural curiosity. Uzbek learners study it for work, in tourism or through scholarships abroad. Most aim for HSK Level 4, the usual baseline for a job. [Q: Xiang Wei (director) on demand for Chinese speakers] The state is pushing the same way. In September 2025, President Mirziyoyev announced more than 100 native Chinese-speaking teachers for Uzbek schools and universities, to support projects agreed with Chinese companies.

The teachers have adapted, adding role-play for quieter students and using AI tools to plan lessons.

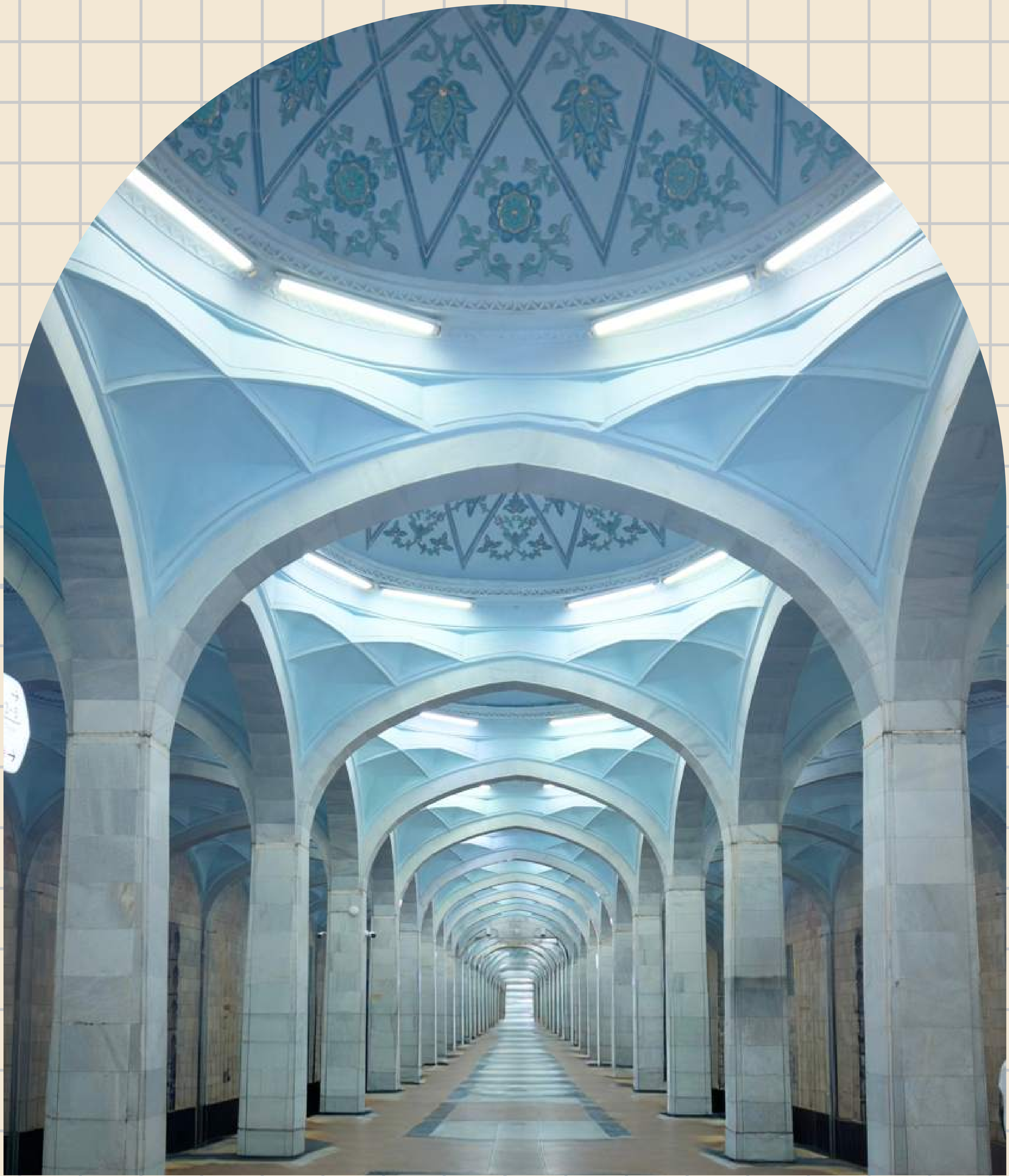
If the partnership ended, Chinese teaching here would continue, because SSIFL runs its own program. It would simply have less of China in it.



CHANNEL II • KNOWLEDGE

A textbook, a certificate, a fourth language. What travels furthest is what the learner gets to keep.





CHANNEL III – INHERITANCE

Buildings That Never Stopped Working

A square of old colleges, a university that claims one of them, a trading city, and a metro whose builder no longer exists. None of them ever stopped working.

Registan Square: Cells Built for Scholars, Let to Traders

The rooms around these courtyards were built for students. Today artisans rent them, and that is nothing new.

We reached the Registan on our first afternoon in Samarkand, in heat even sharper than Tashkent's. Three madrasas, or Islamic colleges, face the square: Ulugh Beg (1417–1420), Sher-Dor (1619–1636) and Tilla-Kari (1646–1660).

We had no guide, so we watched how the buildings are used. Around each courtyard runs a ring of hujra cells, the small rooms where students once lived. Now artisans sell embroidered textiles, miniature paintings and carved wooden boxes there. It is a market for handmade craft, which is different from turning the rooms into ordinary shops.

It would be easy to call this a modern compromise. The records say otherwise. The Ulugh Beg madrasa taught students until the late 1600s, then stored grain for more than a century. Teaching returned in the early 1900s. Now it is a craft market. Reuse is not something done to this building. It is the building's whole history.

Keeping it standing is a living skill as well. Restoration has carried these walls through repeated earthquakes, and the work continues today.

MARGA SUTRA • FIELD PASS

SITE

Registan Square

BUILT

1417–1660, over about 240 years

USED FOR NOW

Craft market and heritage site

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

Restoration never stopped

CITY

Samarkand

BUILT FOR

Teaching and housing students

HOW WE SAW IT

Unguided °

CHANNEL

INHERITANCE

DATE

13 Jul

PAGE

p.30

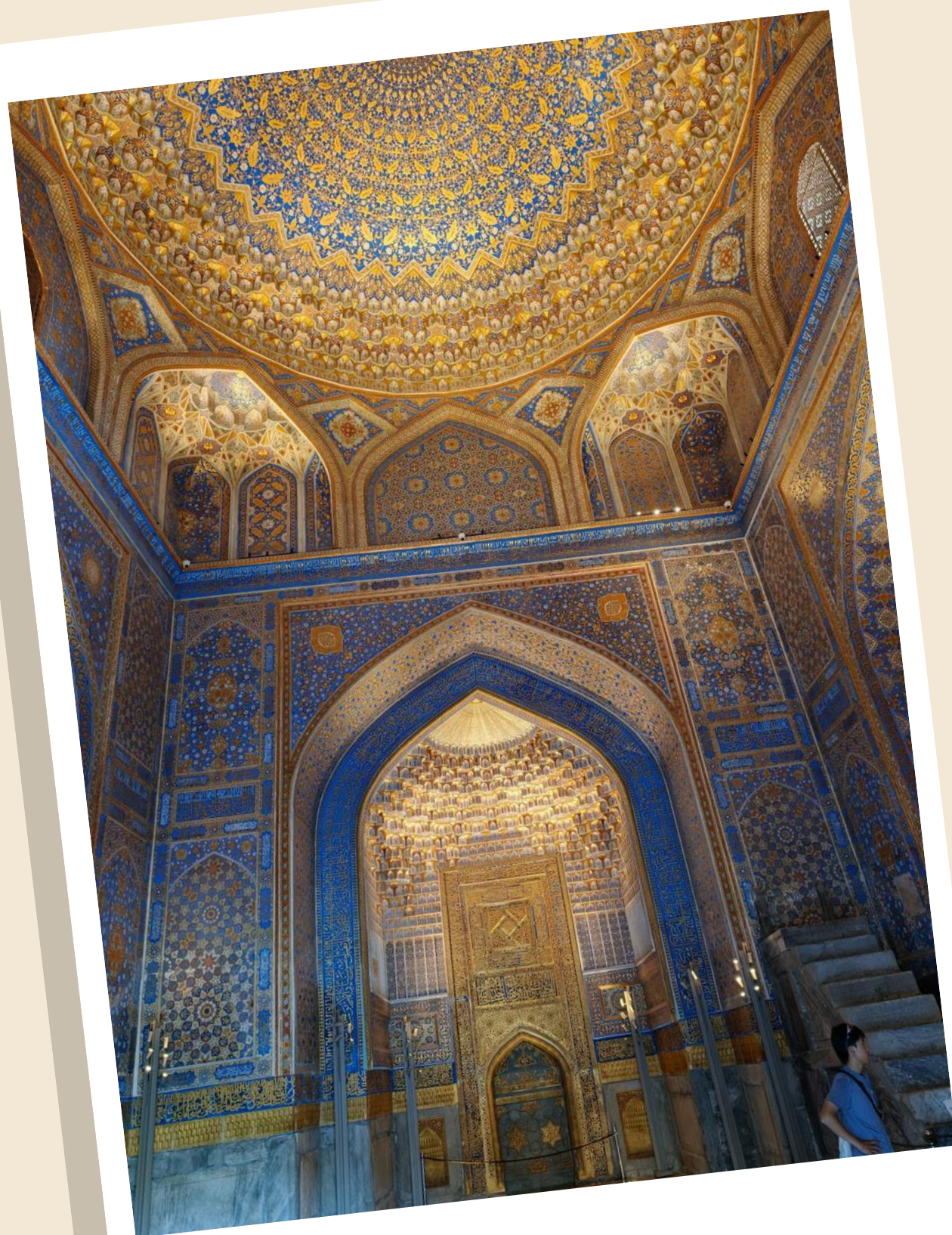
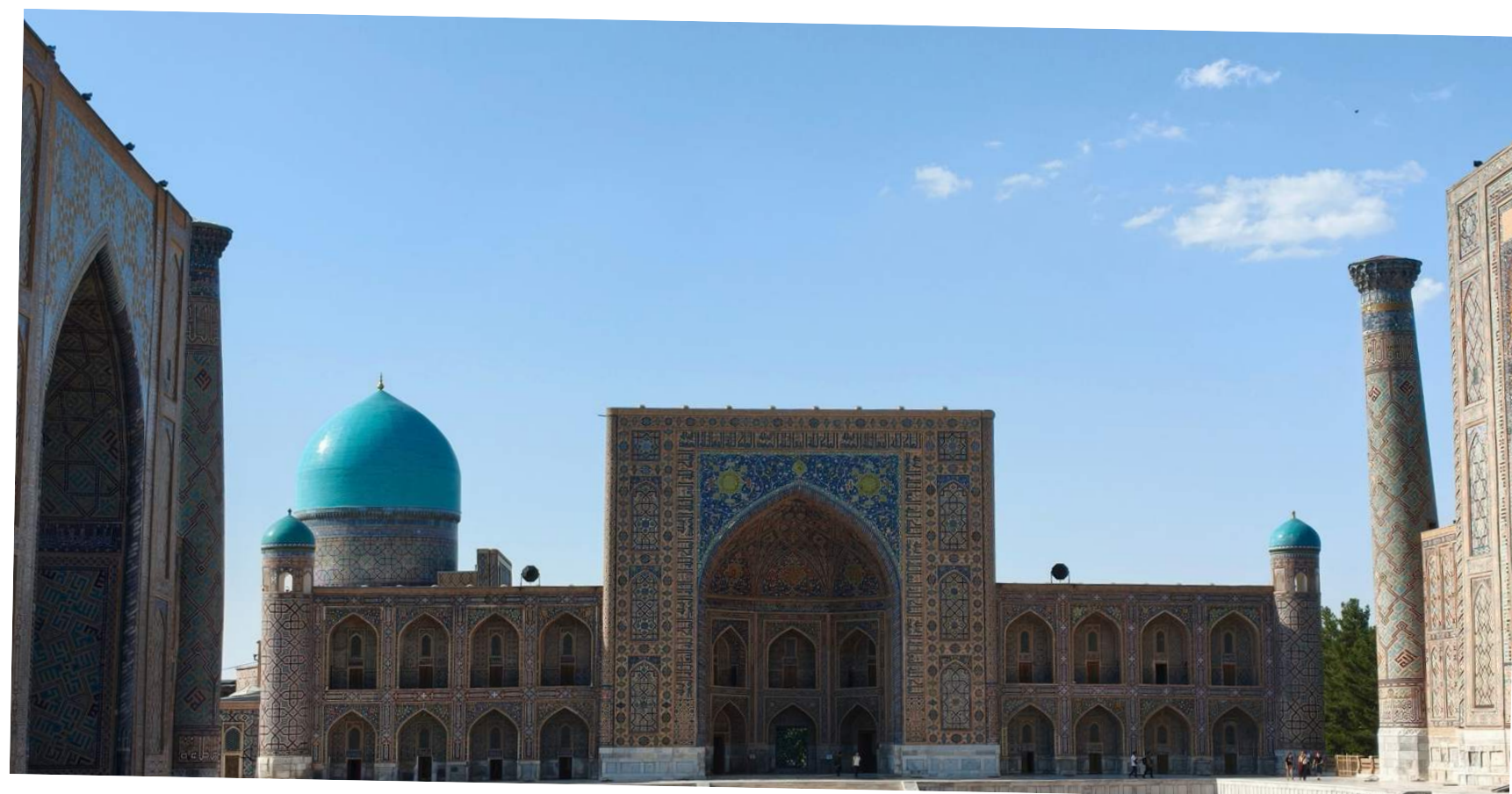
KNOT CODE

UNGUIDED VISIT

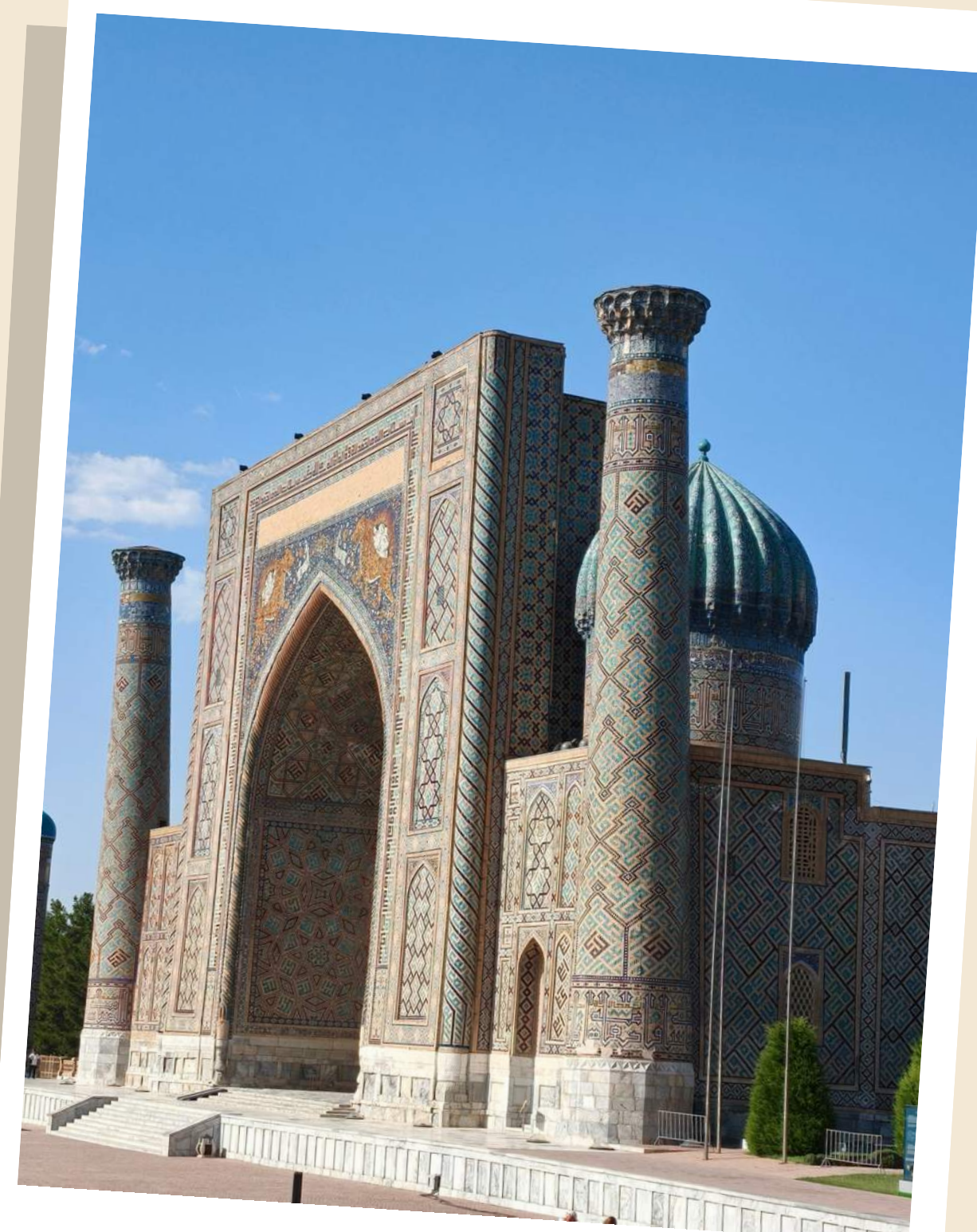
MARGA SUTRA

REGISTAN SQUARE · SAMARKAND · 13 JUL

The square: Ulugh Beg, Sher-Dor and Tilla-Kari, built between 1417 and 1660.



Inside Tilla-Kari: the gilded dome.



Sher-Dor madrasa



Group photo: Marga Sutra on the Registan, 13 July 2026.

[PLACEHOLDER: these 4 photos are still Bukhara copies. Drop in Registan photos: square, Tilla-Kari dome, courtyard cells, group.]

SAMARKAND STATE UNIVERSITY · 16 JUL

Our host at the welcome meeting.



Archaeology museum: a guide takes us through the university's collection, 16 July 2026.



A lecture hall on the campus tour.



Group photo: Marga Sutra with our hosts under the university sign.

Samarkand State University: Six Centuries, Claimed

The university traces its line to a madrasa founded in 1420. Its labs are aiming at quantum computing.

On the morning of 16 July we met Vice Rector Akmal Akhatov, with professors and students, at Samarkand State University. The welcome presentation and the printed materials put one claim first: the university descends from the Ulugh Beg madrasa, founded in 1420. That is the building on p.30, the one that spent more than a century storing grain. Teaching did not continue there without a break. It moved, it stopped, and it was later claimed back as lineage by a university elsewhere in the city. We record the claim as SamSU's own account of itself, because the gap between the story and the building shows how heritage is put to work.

We toured the university's archaeology museum, but the labs point the other way. At the Samarkand Quantum Center, researchers make perovskite nanocrystals, aiming at qubits, the building blocks of quantum computers. It is an unusual specialty for the region, and we were told it is a deliberate choice. The university has also built a 3D model of the Registan. It is not meant to replace a visit. It is an introduction, so visitors understand what they are seeing before they arrive. SRIU (p.23) trains the people who will receive tourists. SamSU prepares the tourists.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

SamsU

BUILT

1927

USED FOR NOW

Teaching, a museum,
quantum research

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

It claims the lineage

CITY

Samarkand

BUILT FOR

Training teachers

HOW WE SAW IT

Hosted

CHANNEL

INHERITANCE

DATE

16 Jul

PAGE

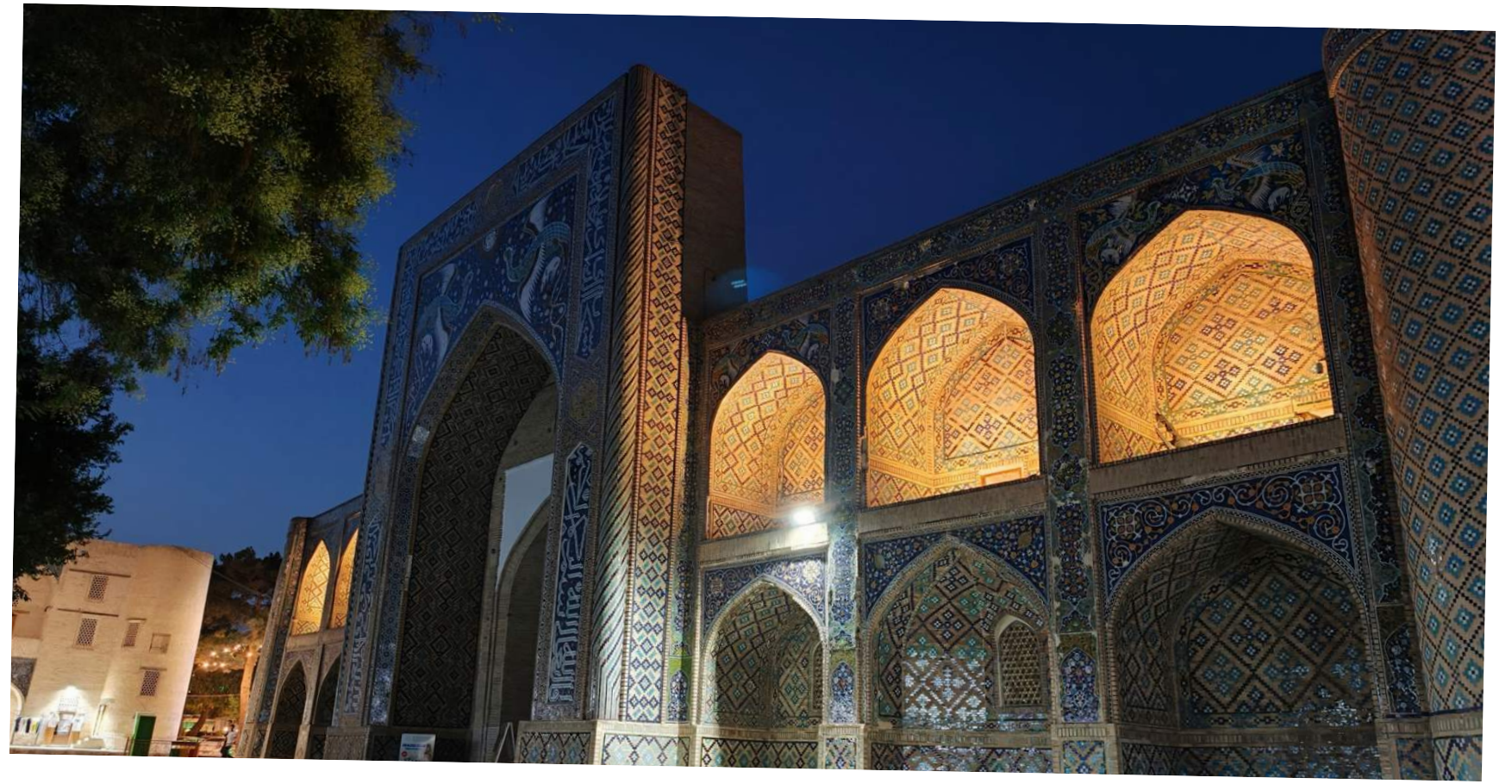
p.33

KNOT CODE

33

BUKHARA OLD CITY · 19 JUL

Arcades lit after dark: the old city stays open, and busy, late into the evening.



A lit gateway on our evening walk, 19 July 2026.



The Kalan Minaret, built in 1127, lit against the night sky.



Group photo: Marga Sutra in the old city after dark.

Bukhara After Dark: One Block, Two Lives

At night, a courtyard restaurant felt strangely familiar. Two days earlier, we had walked in from the other side.

Bukhara's afternoons reached 45°C, so we saved the old city for the evening of 19 July. With no guide, we walked from Lyab-i-Hauz, where diners sit inches from the old pool, through the covered trading domes to the Kalan Minaret.

Nothing on that walk was fenced off. The domes were built for trade, and they still trade: textiles, souvenirs, food. Around the minaret, residents and foreign visitors shared the same square. A neon restaurant sign glowed above the centuries-old Nodir Devon Begi Madrasa. For a moment it looked wrong. Then it looked right, because this was always a market town.

Then came the surprise. Walking through the courtyards of a night-time venue, one of us recognized the layout. It was the same historic block as the carpet workshop we had visited on 17 July (p.44), entered from the opposite side. By day the building holds looms; by night it serves dinner. From either entrance, you would never guess the other.

Bukhara does not keep its old buildings for one use. Here, one building keeps two.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

Kalan Minaret & Old City

BUILT

Kalan Minaret 1127; the rest over centuries

USED FOR NOW

Restaurants, shops and craft

IF THE PARTNER LEFT

It never stopped trading

CITY

Bukhara

BUILT FOR

Trade and worship

HOW WE SAW IT

Evening walk, unguided °

CHANNEL

III

INHERITANCE

DATE

19 Jul

PAGE

p.35

KNOT CODE

UNGUIDED VISIT

MARGA SUTRA

The Tashkent Metro: A Transfer With No Partner Left

Built in 1977 as a Soviet technology transfer. The country that built it is gone. The trains still run.

On 12 July we spent a day riding the Tashkent Metro with no guide, changing lines just to see the stations. No two looked alike. Each had its own ceilings, lights and decoration, closer to a museum gallery than a train stop. At the entrances stood heavy blast doors, because the system was also designed as a civil defense shelter.

The metro opened in 1977, the first in Central Asia. It was a Soviet technology transfer. In 1991 the Soviet Union dissolved, and the partner that had supplied the technology disappeared completely.

Uzbekistan kept the metro running anyway. For more than three decades it has operated, maintained and extended the network by itself.

The field cards for the cooperation projects in this book all ask one question: if the foreign partner left, what would happen? Everywhere else, the answer is a forecast. Here, it is history. The partner left. The trains still run.

MARGA SUTRA • FIELD PASS

SITE

The Tashkent Metro

BUILT

1977, the first metro in Central Asia

USED FOR NOW

Daily transport

STILL WORKING BECAUSE

Uzbekistan kept it running after 1991.

CITY

Tashkent

BUILT FOR

Transport, and shelter in wartime

HOW WE SAW IT

Riding it, unguided °

CHANNEL

III

INHERITANCE

DATE

12 Jul

PAGE

p.36

UNGUIDED VISIT

MARGA SUTRA

KNOT CODE

CHANNEL III • INHERITANCE

None of this is behind glass. It stayed in use, which is harder, and it is why it is still here.





CHANNEL IV – CAPABILITY

What Stays When the Partner Leaves

Uzbekistan built everything on these pages itself: a university, a free youth center and a carpet workshop. What do they build, and who gets in?

Green University: Ecology, Argued as Employment

Uzbekistan is short of about 8,000 environmental professionals. This university sells ecology as a career, and students are signing up.

Green University's full name is the Central Asian University of Environmental and Climate Change Studies. It was founded by presidential decree, and our hosts presented that as proof that the government means it.

The case they made was not about saving the planet. It was about jobs. By law, every new industrial project in Uzbekistan needs an Environmental Impact Assessment, or EIA. That creates demand for people who can write, check and enforce them, and the country is short of about 8,000.

So the university presents ecology as employment. Its most popular major is Environmental Law, because it leads straight to work as a prosecutor or an advocate. Other students train for green banking, circular economies and sustainable finance. Even the sociology department focuses on quantitative data. The campus works as a hub, sending students from fourteen colleges toward ten research institutes.

There is one catch, and it is about time. The shortage exists today. The university is very new, and it is not yet producing graduates in large numbers.



GREEN UNIVERSITY · TASHKENT · 11 JUL

Meeting room: a long table under the library shelves, 11 July 2026.



Rector of the University:
the plan is a hub that links
students from 14 colleges to
10 research institutes.

Our side of the table:
Marga Sutra learning how
Environmental Law leads
to careers as prosecutors.



Group photo: Marga
Sutra with the university
officials in the library.

YOUTH AFFAIRS · BUKHARA · 18 JUL

The tour: teenagers who study at the center showed us around, 18 July 2026.



Chess club: one of the free courses, next to coding, robotics and languages.

Classroom: screens and computers for the center's coding courses.



Group photo: Marga Sutra with our hosts and young guides.

Youth Affairs: The Young Architects of Society

At Bukhara's free youth center, AI tools are banned from the coding classes, on purpose.

Our guide at the Bukhara Youth Affairs Department was not an official. She was a young woman of about seventeen who uses the center herself. She led the group, set the pace and handled questions she could not have prepared for.

The center offers robotics, web development, foreign languages and chess to young people from primary school age upward. Everything is free. There is no entrance exam and no language barrier. In one room, a teacher was building a website's backend in Django, a Python framework, line by line.

Then came the rule that stopped us: AI tools are banned in the programming courses. Staff told us why. Students must work through the logic of software themselves, instead of reaching an answer by shortcut. The center accepts slower progress in exchange for skill that lasts.

In Samarkand, the Confucius Institute uses AI to plan its lessons (p.26). Two schools in one country reached opposite answers about the same technology, and both make sense. One wants students who can work in Chinese. The other wants students who can build software without help.

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

Youth Affairs

CITY

Bukhara

STARTED BY

The state youth service, run locally

WHO GETS IN

Anyone: free, no exam

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING

State youth policy

SUCCESS MEANS

Real skill, not finished output

RUNNING SINCE

2020

CHANNEL

IV

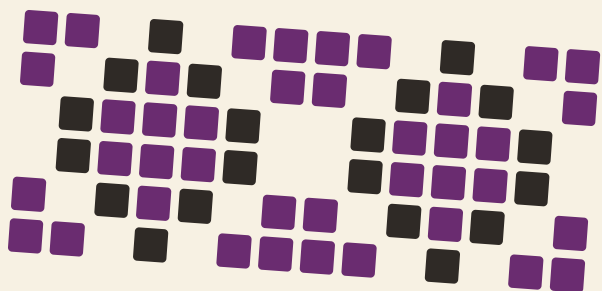
CAPABILITY

DATE

18 Jul

PAGE

p.43



KNOT CODE

The Carpet Workshop: A Map of Every Knot

Every knot in a Bukhara carpet is planned on a map first. The workshop will teach anyone to read it, for free.

On the loom floor, nobody was improvising. Each weaver worked from a talim, a coded pattern map that gives the color of every knot, row by row. Artisans told us one carpet takes twelve to eighteen months of steady work. Finished pieces sell for a few hundred to several thousand US dollars, depending on size and detail.

What surprised us was not the price. It was the open door. The workshop teaches its technique free of charge to anyone who wants to learn, local or foreign, at each learner's own pace. There is no fee, no nationality rule and no entrance test. Most of its weavers are women, working across a spread-out network rather than in one factory hall.

We were told about the training, not shown it, so this is their account. The logic, though, is simple. A trainee who finishes can weave, sell and teach without ever coming back. The skill leaves with them.

The same building has a second life after dark (p.35).

MARGA SUTRA · FIELD PASS

SITE

Carpet Factory

STARTED BY

Uzbek, and paid for by its own sales

WHO GETS IN

Anyone, local or foreign, for free

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING

Carpet sales

CITY

Bukhara

SUCCESS MEANS

Quality, and keeping the craft alive

RUNNING SINCE

2010 (fifth-generation)

CHANNEL

IV

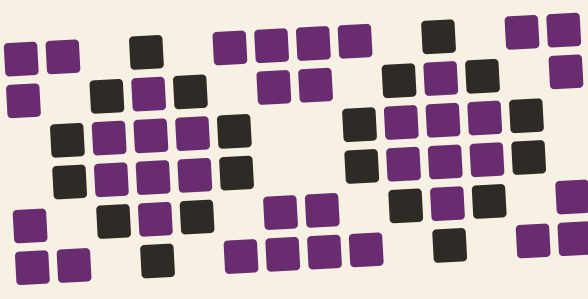
CAPABILITY

DATE

17 Jul

PAGE

p.44



KNOT CODE

CHANNEL IV • CAPABILITY

A weaver, an environmental lawyer, a teenager learning backend code. Nobody arranged any of it from outside.

What We Found

Fourteen sites, one set of questions. Four answers, and one surprise.

- 1 Everything here has a job.**

Ecology is sold as law enforcement, language as employment and heritage as tourism income. Subjects that count as "soft" elsewhere recruit well in Uzbekistan, because nobody presents them as soft.
- 2 Owning more does not mean keeping more.**

BYD's venture is mostly Uzbek-owned, but it imports its key parts. CE-SAM has no Uzbek owner, yet most of its staff are Uzbek. Ownership decides who shares the profit. Skill has to be built on purpose.
- 3 A gift is not a skill.**

A village well and road repairs funded by CE-SAM help real people, but they do not leave anyone able to build the next one. A textbook, a certificate or a weaving technique stays with the person and can be passed on. In our sample, gifts came mostly from Chinese projects and skills mostly from Uzbek ones. Both matter. Only skills keep growing.
- 4 Industry predicts dependency, not the flag.**

Factories depend on supply chains, whoever starts them. B.A. Holding is Uzbek, and it still depends on its clothing contracts.

THE SURPRISE

Most of the skill-building we saw that people get to keep was Uzbekistan's own. China brings capital, jobs and infrastructure at scale. How deep that goes depends on what the country has already built to receive it.

A caveat. Fourteen sites, ten days and uneven access are not much. The second and third findings rest on very few cases, and we hope the next team tests them.

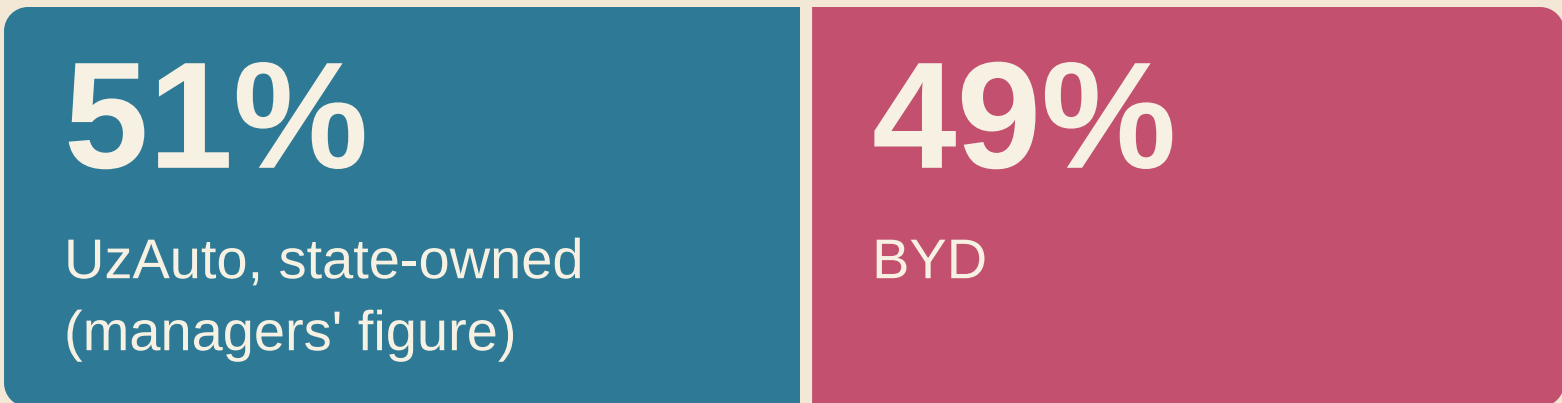
Who owns it, and what is local?

Uzbek Chinese

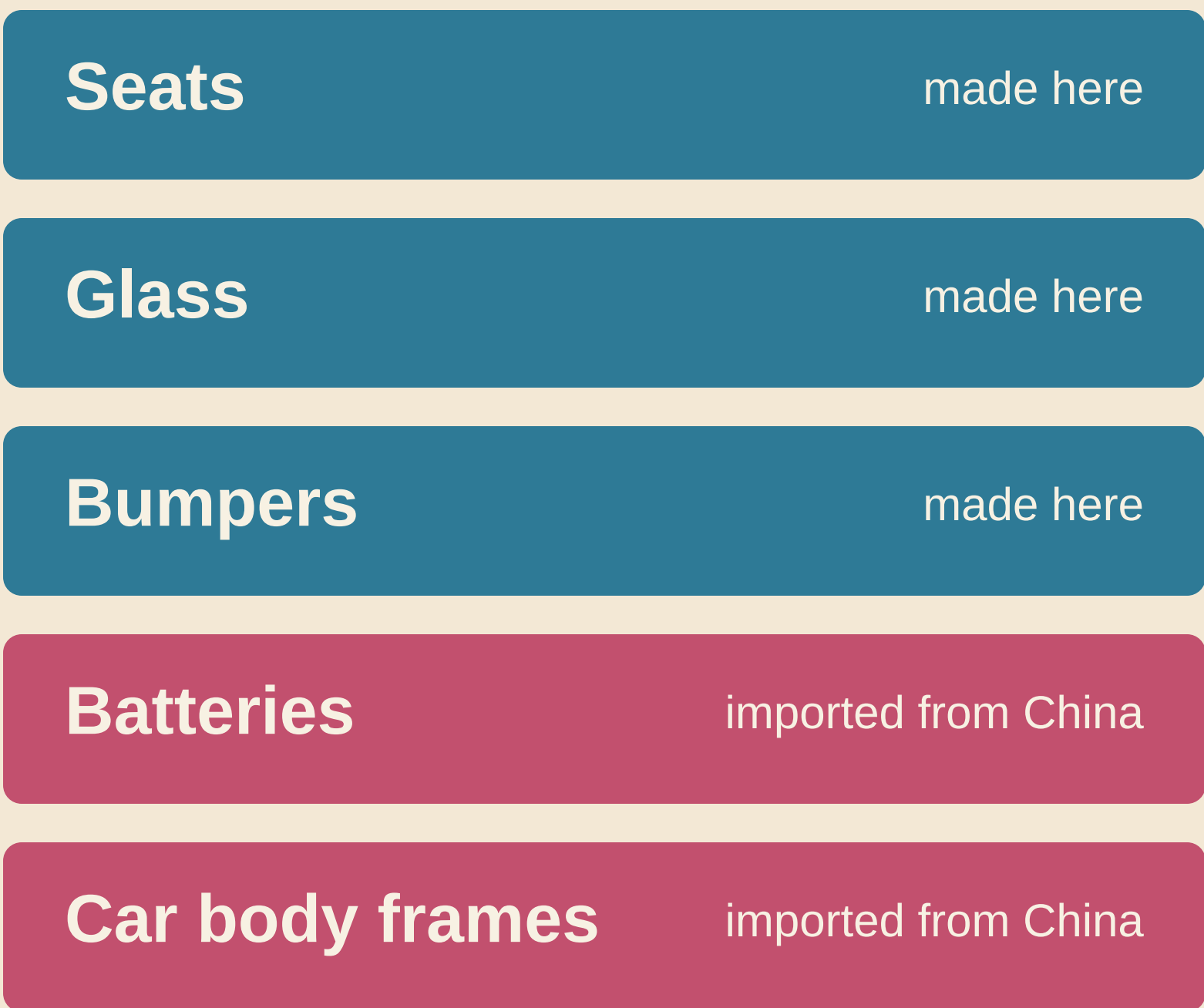
BYD Uzbekistan Factory

Joint venture · car production since June 2024

WHO OWNS IT



WHAT IS LOCAL *counted in parts*



3 made here 2 imported

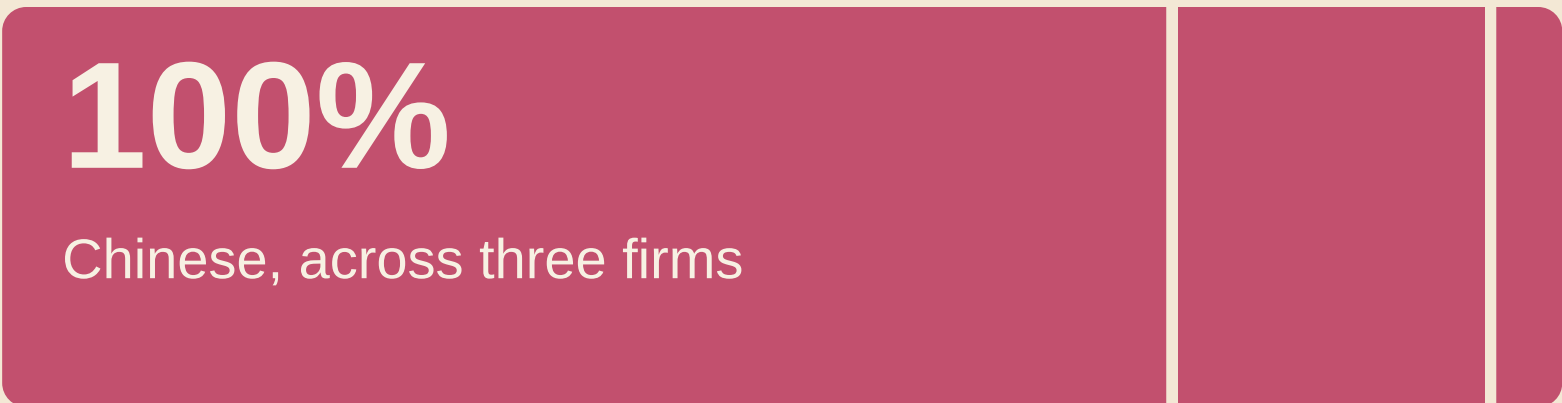
Source: managers at BYD's sales office, Tashkent, 10 July

Columns are not to scale with each other

CE-SAM

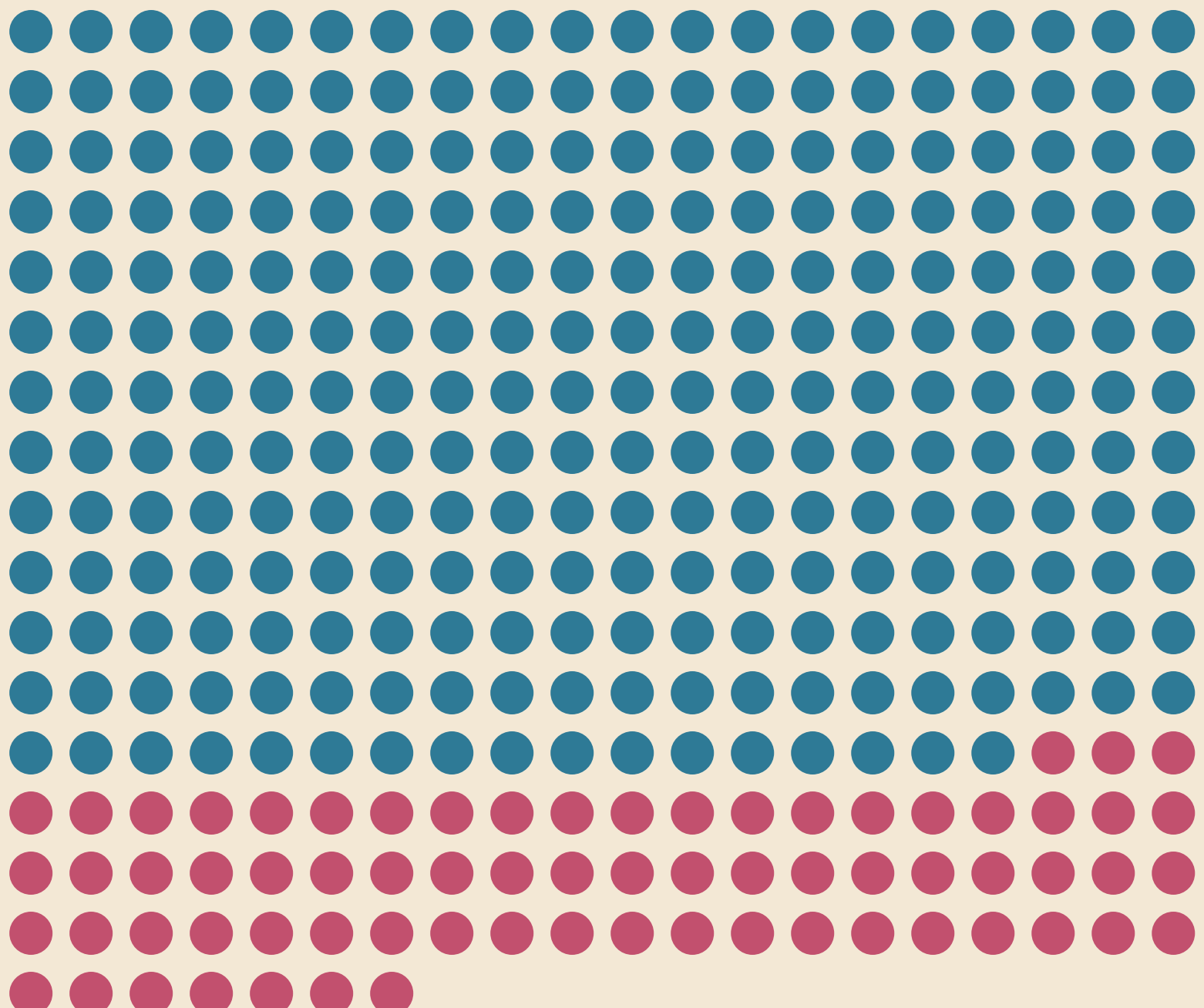
Cement plant · selling since November 2023

WHO OWNS IT



China Energy International Group Overseas Investment 75% · Gezhouba Cement 20% · Gansu Hengya 5%

WHAT IS LOCAL *counted in people*



257 Uzbek 70 Chinese

Source: CE-SAM company presentation, Samarkand, 14 July



Full stories: BYD p.16 · CE-SAM p.15

Ownership and local depth point in different directions. The two columns measure different things, parts at BYD and people at CE-SAM, so read them as a mismatch, not a ranking. Both had been running for a similar time, so time alone does not explain the gap.

Four Ways of Seeing the Same Eleven Days

Same trip, same three questions, four people.



Jethro Rafferty Tomosegu

林才多

TEAM LEADER · ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING AND AUTOMATION

- 1 I picked it because its economy is growing fast, side by side with China, and I wanted to see how they manage and did their developments in practice. Observing from every aspects: private companies, governmental organizations, historical
- 2 The team itself. It was my first time leading abroad, and my Chinese is limited. My teammates took on different roles without being asked, which allows me join the research and talks instead of only coordinating it.
- 3 I started out feeling responsible for making all this work. I ended grateful that it became everyone's job. Leadership, for me, now means building the trust that lets each person's strength count.

Alif Farhan Nugraha

杨启恩

CHIEF WRITER · ADVANCED INTELLIGENT COMPUTING

- 1 Writing wasn't new to me. I spent two years on my high school journalism team. Ten days, fourteen sites and one report was a different scale.
- 2 Who fears AI, and who already uses it. At SSIFL, a vice director worried it would replace translators. At the Confucius Institute, teachers plan their lessons with it. For someone studying AI, both answers were about my own future.
- 3 The hardest part was choosing what to leave out, or the report would have run to 30,000 words. Ten days taught me more about how development works than a semester of reading.



THE THREE QUESTIONS

- 1 What did you expect?
- 2 What did you see that the others didn't?
- 3 What are you taking home?

Farras Fakhрил Anam

赵宇辰

FINANCE · ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING AND AUTOMATION

- 1 To me, infrastructure meant roads, buildings and transit lines. By the first evening, after a publisher showed us its translated books, it also meant literature.
- 2 A computer made of wood. In Bukhara, a weaver read a talim and tied knots row by row, like pixels on a grid. One wrong knot and the whole medallion is off. Why do we call that handicraft, and an app engineering?
- 3 Heritage isn't frozen in stone. Bukhara's old trading domes are still full of stalls and cafes. History is meant to be used, not just observed.



Rafi Adifa Maulana

瑞峰

DESIGNER · ENGINEERING IN URBAN PLANNING

- 1 I expected Uzbekistan to feel foreign. It didn't. I never had to think about where to find a mosque, or whether the meat was halal.
- 2 On the train to Bukhara, the attendant spoke to me in Uzbek and thought I was local. All trip I'd called myself the Indonesian at the third corner, outside both sides. For a few seconds, I wasn't outside anything.
- 3 A question I can't settle. Feeling at home made the trip easier. I still don't know if it made me a better observer, or just a more comfortable one.



Thanks, Sources and Credits

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TASHKENT

SRIDI
BYD Central Asia
B.A. Holding
Green University

SAMARKAND

CE-SAM
Silk Road International
University
The Confucius Institute at
SSIFL
Samarkand State University
SSIFL

BUKHARA

Bukhara Silk and Carpet
Factory
Bukhara Youth Affairs
Department

Sources. Everything here comes from our visits in July 2026 and from our full report, which lists every source. Scan a code to read more.

OUR FINAL REPORTS, MAGAZINE & ARTICLE



The final article
Opens all three city stories



This magazine online
Read or share the digital edition



The full report
Every visit, every source



Tashkent



Samarkand

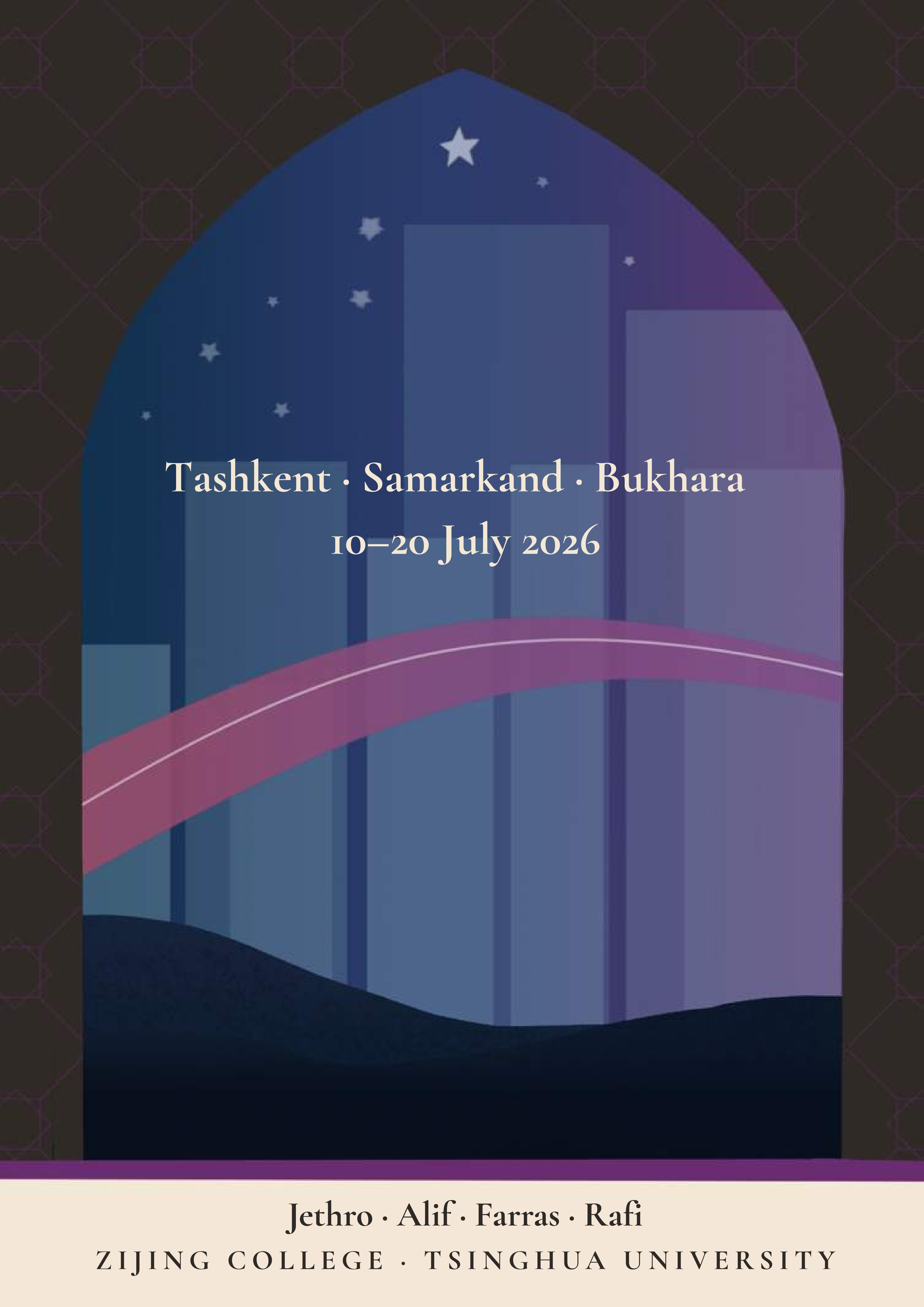


Bukhara

Credits. Videographer & Video Editor: Jethro Rafferty Tomosegu · Text: Alif Farhan Nugraha · Editor: Farras Fakhрил Anam · Design & Editor: Rafi Adifa Maulana · Photos: Marga Sutra, unless credited.

Deep Dive Uzbekistan. Marga Sutra 兹路之径, Zijing College, Tsinghua University.
Set in Poppins, Nunito Sans and Noto Sans SC. Not for sale.





Tashkent · Samarkand · Bukhara
10–20 July 2026

Jethro · Alif · Farras · Rafi
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